MomentsHub: State Transition Diagram Analysis

Software Engineering - BCSE301P

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Assignment: State Transition Diagram Documentation

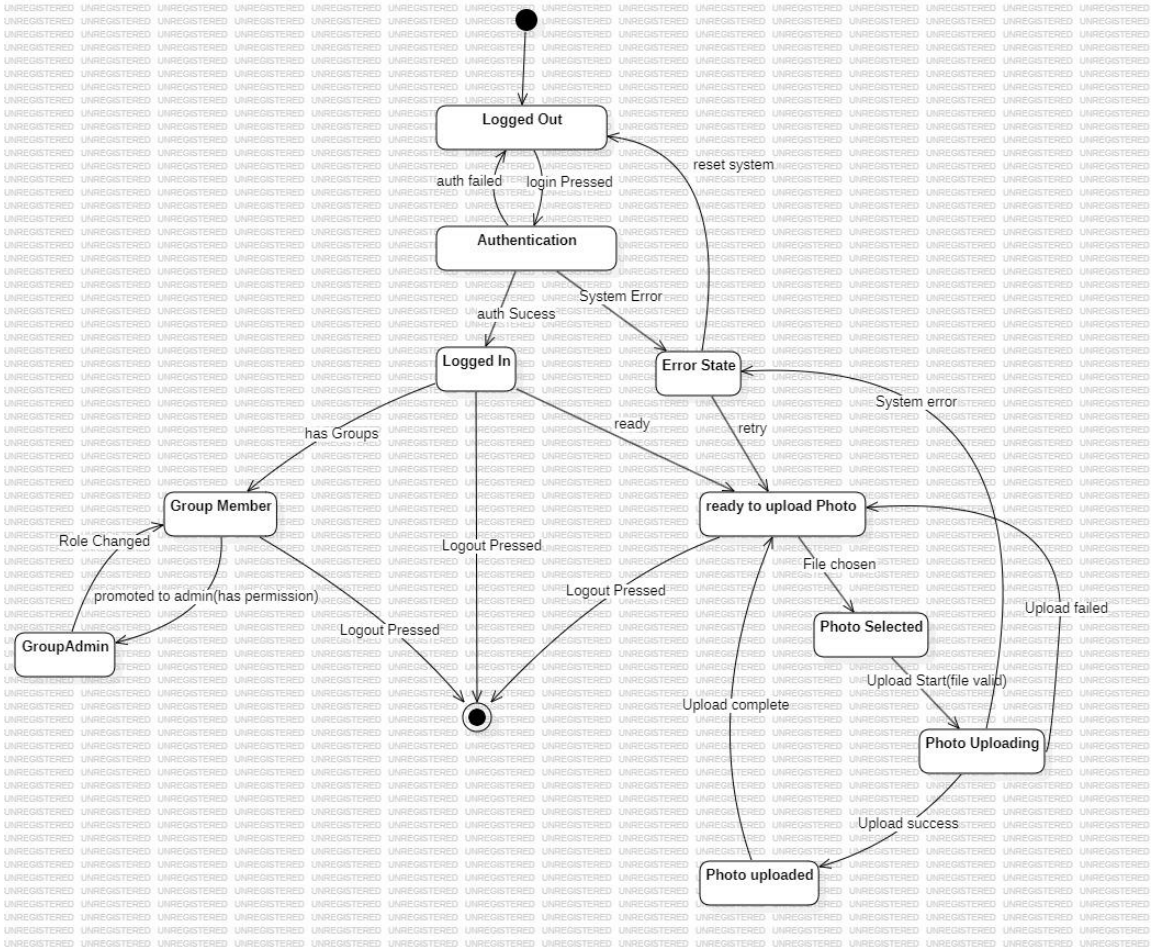
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1. Introduction

This document provides a detailed analysis of the Statechart Diagram for the **MomentsHub** application. While the activity diagram illustrates the flow of user actions and system processes, this statechart diagram focuses on the different states an object or the system itself can be in throughout its lifecycle. It models the object's condition from creation to termination, detailing the events that trigger transitions from one state to another. This is crucial for understanding system stability, user session management, and the lifecycle of core processes like photo uploads.

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2. Key State-Transition Models



The diagram can be broken down into several key models that describe the behavior of different aspects of the application.

2.1 User Session State Model

This model describes the primary lifecycle of a user's interaction with the application, from initial entry to logging out.

- **Flow:** Logged Out → Authentication → Logged In → (End State)
- **Key States:**
    - **Logged Out**: The initial state of any user session before authentication. The system is awaiting user action.
    - **Authentication**: A transient state entered when a user presses the login button. The system is actively verifying credentials.
    - **Logged In**: A primary state representing an authenticated, active user session. From here, the user can access all core application features.
- **Key Transitions:**
    - Login Pressed: An event triggered by the user that moves the session from Logged Out to Authentication.
    - auth Success: An internal system event that transitions the session to the Logged In state upon successful credential validation.
    - auth failed: An event that returns the user to the Logged Out state if credentials are invalid.
    - Logout Pressed: A user-initiated event from the Logged In state (or its sub-states) that terminates the session and moves it to the final state.

2.2 User Role State Model

This model is a sub-state of the Logged In state, showing how a user's permissions and role can change dynamically within a group.

- **Flow:** Logged In → Group Member ↔ GroupAdmin
- **Key States:**
    - **Group Member**: The default state for a user within a group. They have standard permissions like viewing and uploading photos.
    - **GroupAdmin**: A privileged state for users with administrative rights, allowing them to manage members and group settings.

- **Key Transitions:**
    - has groups: The transition from Logged In to Group Member, occurring when the system confirms the user belongs to at least one group.
    - promoted to admin (has permission): An event, likely triggered by another admin, that elevates a Group Member to a GroupAdmin.
    - Role Changed: An event that can demote a GroupAdmin back to a Group Member.

2.3 Photo Upload State Model

This model details the step-by-step lifecycle of the photo upload process, which begins once a user is Logged In.

- **Flow:** ready to upload Photo → Photo Selected → Photo Uploading → Photo uploaded
- **Key States:**
    - **ready to upload Photo**: The system is waiting for the user to initiate an upload.
    - **Photo Selected**: The user has chosen a file from their device, but the upload has not yet begun.
    - **Photo Uploading**: The system is actively transferring the file to Firebase Storage. This state can transition to success, failure, or a system error.
    - **Photo uploaded**: The final success state, indicating the photo is securely stored and available in the gallery.
- **Key Transitions:**
    - File chosen: Moves from waiting to having a file selected.
    - Upload Start (file valid): Begins the transfer process after initial validation.
    - Upload success: Confirms the successful completion of the upload.
    - Upload failed: Returns the user to the ready to upload Photo state if the upload is interrupted or fails, allowing them to try again.

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3. Statechart Diagram Components

3.1 UML Elements Used

- **Initial/Final States**: The diagram uses a single solid black circle for the initial state before login and a circle with a border for the final state after logout.
- **States**: Represented by rectangles with rounded corners (e.g., Logged In, Photo Uploading). They signify a specific condition or status of an object.
- **Transitions**: Represented by directed arrows. They show the path from one state to another, triggered by an event.
- **Events**: The text labels on the transitions (e.g., Login Pressed, Upload success). These are the triggers that cause a state change.

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4. Error Handling and System Resilience

The diagram features a dedicated Error State to model system-wide exception handling, which is crucial for creating a robust application.

- **Centralized Error Handling**: The Error State acts as a catch-all for unexpected system failures that can occur during critical processes like Authentication or Photo Uploading.
- **Recovery Paths**:
    - **retry**: This transition allows the system to attempt to recover from a transient error. For example, if a photo upload fails due to a brief network issue, a retry event could move the system from the Error State back to the ready to upload Photo state.
    - **reset system**: This transition handles more critical, non-recoverable errors. It forces the user session back to the Logged Out state, ensuring the app is in a safe and stable condition.

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5. Development Implications

This statechart diagram serves as a direct blueprint for implementation, particularly for frontend state management and backend validation.

5.1 Frontend Development

- The diagram maps perfectly to state management libraries like **Redux**, **MobX**, or React's built-in **Context API**. Each state in the diagram can be represented by a state variable in the application's global store.
- The transitions define the actions or dispatchers that will be called to update the application's state based on user input or system events. For example, a C++

application using a state machine pattern could directly implement these states and transitions.

5.2 Backend Integration

- The backend must enforce the logic of these state transitions. For example, the server must validate that a user has admin permissions before allowing the transition from Group Member to GroupAdmin.
- The backend is responsible for emitting the events (auth Success, Upload success) that drive state changes on the client-side.

5.3 Testing Strategy

- The diagram provides a clear guide for **state-based testing**. Test cases should be written to verify every possible transition, including valid flows, invalid attempts (e.g., a non-admin trying to access admin functions), and error conditions.

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6. Conclusion

The statechart diagram for **MomentsHub** is an essential tool that complements the activity diagram. It provides a clear and unambiguous model of the application's behavior from a state-based perspective. By defining all possible states and the exact events that cause transitions between them, this diagram ensures that the application will be predictable, stable, and resilient. It will serve as a foundational guide for my teammate and me during the development phase, helping us implement robust state management logic and comprehensive error handling.